



Interagency Recovery Coordination's Support for North Carolina's Recovery

DR-4827-NC

FEMA

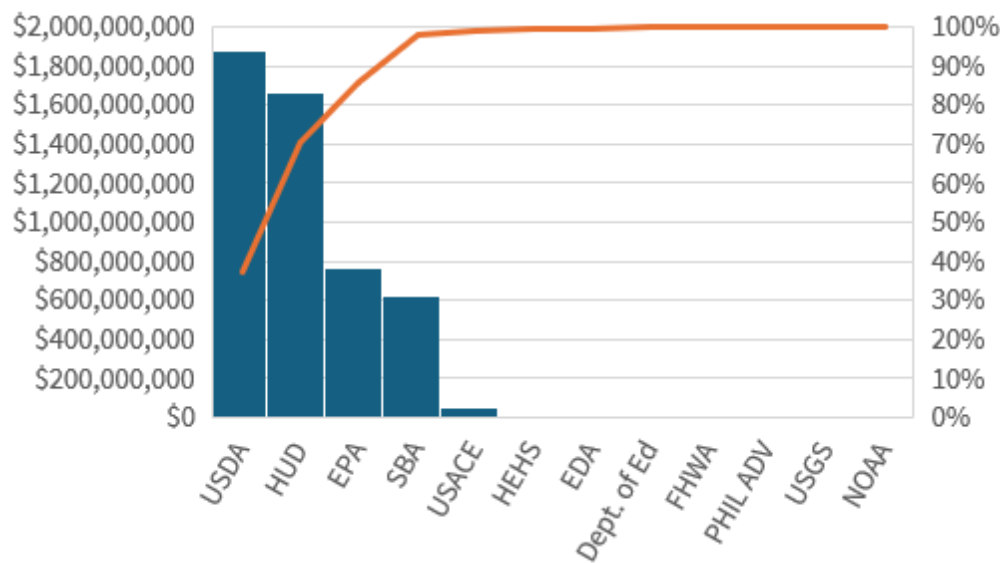
The Challenge

Beginning in late September 2024, Hurricane Helene brought historic rainfall, landslides, and catastrophic river flooding to western North Carolina. Downtown business districts, neighborhoods, and critical facilities in communities such as Asheville, Canton, Old Fort, Marshall, Lake Lure, Chimney Rock, and Yancey and Avery Counties were inundated. Wastewater plants and drinking water systems failed, roads and bridges were washed out (including hundreds of private bridges and access roads), and tens of thousands of residents lost power, housing, and safe water. Debris impacts also drove a long-term increase in wildfire and landslide risk across the region.

From October 2024 through March 2026, FEMA's Interagency Recovery Coordination (IRC) team worked with state, tribal, local, federal, philanthropic, private, and faith-based partners to stabilize conditions and lay the groundwork for long-term, locally led recovery and resilience.

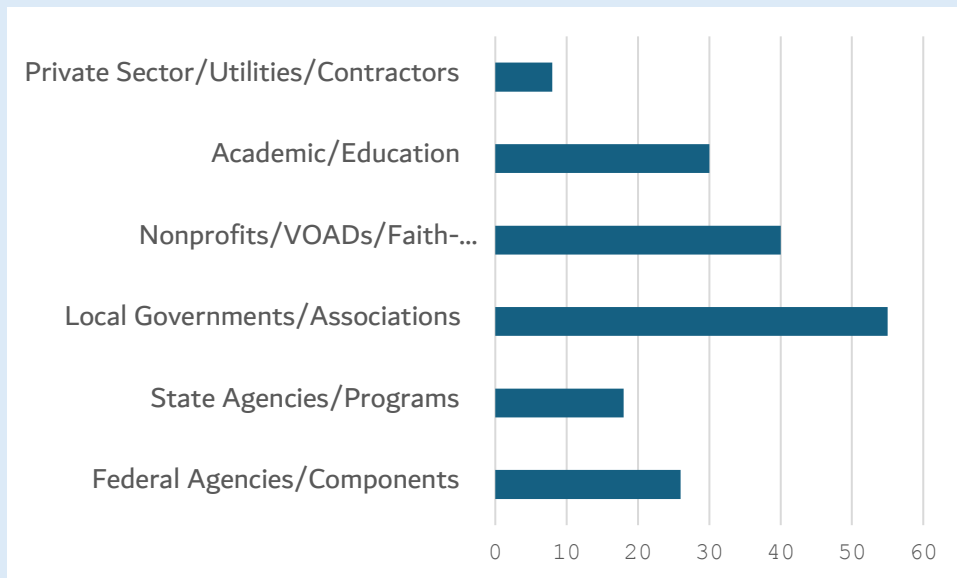
Funding

FEMA's IRC team plays a critical role in channeling funding and resources to support North Carolina's recovery from Hurricane Helene. Through its mission-assigned advisors, IRC coordinates with federal, state, local, philanthropic, and private partners to identify needs, align funding streams, and facilitate access to billions of dollars in recovery investments for impacted communities.



Collaboration

FEMA's Interagency Recovery Coordination (IRC) team collaborates closely with state, tribal, local, federal, philanthropic, private, and faith-based partners to stabilize conditions and drive long-term recovery in western North Carolina after Hurricane Helene. Through joint planning, workshops, and coordinated funding initiatives, IRC helps align resources and expertise across agencies and organizations to address critical needs in housing, infrastructure, health, economic recovery, and environmental resilience.



Projects

The IRC team plays a central role in organizing and guiding recovery projects by aligning federal, state, and local resources across key Recovery Support Functions (RSFs). Through its advisors and collaborative approach, IRC ensures that projects addressing infrastructure, housing, health, economic recovery, natural resources, and community assistance are coordinated efficiently to meet the diverse needs of impacted communities.

Recovery Support Function / Advisor	Approximate Project Count
Infrastructure	25
Community Assistance	20
Health, Education and Human Services	18
Economic	15
Natural and Cultural Resources	13
Housing	10

Recovery Support Function / Advisor	Approximate Project Count
Sustainability Advisor	8
Unified Federal Review Advisor	7
USDA Advisor	12
Philanthropy Advisor	7
SBA Advisor	6

Project Highlights

Water, Wastewater, and Infrastructure

- SRF workshops enabled \$767M+ in water and wastewater investments.
- USACE and SRF funded new wastewater systems and debris removal in towns like Canton and Lake Lure.

Debris, Natural Resources, and Wildfire Risk

- Firewood Initiative repurposed 220+ tons of debris.
- Watershed protection and wildfire risk mitigation advanced.



Lake Lure. before and after debris removal.

Housing, Health, and Human Services

- HUD allocated \$1.42B to the state and \$225M to Asheville for housing repairs.
- Renew NC program launched with \$807M for home rebuilding.
- Project SERV grants and \$2.4M in emergency prescription assistance supported schools and survivors.

Economic Recovery and Agriculture

- SBA approved \$300M+ in disaster loans.
- BRACs opened for business recovery; EDA launched a \$12M supplemental program.
- Nine Agricultural Recovery Centers served 627+ rural households.

Community Recovery and Planning

- Buncombe County Recovery Plan included 90+ projects.
- Regional workshops mapped unmet needs and funding options.

Private Roads and Bridges

- IRC coordinated repairs for hundreds of damaged private bridges.
- Faith-based partners piloted bridge rebuilds, restoring access.



Private bridge replaced by the Mennonite Disaster Service.

Streamlined Environmental Review

- Programmatic agreements shortened review times for infrastructure projects.

IRC Support for Public Assistance (PA) and Unmet Needs

The Interagency Recovery Coordination (IRC) is actively supporting Public Assistance (PA) by addressing unmet needs through targeted coordination, resource identification, and capacity-building efforts. The following bullets summarize IRC's actions and impact, strictly based on the provided documents:

- IRC distributed Philanthropy Recovery Resource Reports to organizations and municipalities (e.g., MadCo Food Coalition, Town of Black Mountain) to help identify funding for urgent needs like temporary facilities and hot meals for seniors. Outreach to foundations and charities is ongoing for both immediate and long-term recovery goals.
- IRC convened meetings with PA and federal partners to assess community needs, prioritize projects, and address funding gaps, including for PA-ineligible applicants. IRC is developing a master project list to help deconflict funding and connect applicants to resources.
- IRC connected PA-ineligible organizations (e.g., non-profit museums, Valle Country Fair) to philanthropic networks and funders, elevating their needs for financial assistance, and tracking economic impacts. IRC forwards resource matches as they are identified.
- IRC facilitated community assistance meetings to help local governments and organizations define projects and inventories, especially for needs not covered by PA (e.g., workforce housing, facilities for the deaf and blind).
- IRC provided public-facing resource portals and reports to help communities identify grants and build partnerships for unmet needs.
- IRC supported volunteer groups with financial needs for operational continuity (e.g., utility bills for volunteer tent sites).